

World in Brief: Wildfires rage in France and Spain; Indian protests force resignation



Photograph: Getty Images

France's prime minister, Sebastien Lecornu, said **wildfires** “have reached a level that has never been seen before”. Around 270,000 people have been evacuated in France and neighbouring **Spain**, as fires moved towards the city of Bordeaux, and high winds complicated efforts to fight blazes outside Madrid. France's armed forces gave assistance, and Spain declared its first national emergency over a wildfire.

Protesters danced and chanted in the streets of Delhi after **India's** education minister **resigned**. Led by a group called the Cockroach Janta Party (after a judge called unemployed youths “cockroaches”), they were **angry** about the leaking of important exam papers and the lack of jobs. Few had expected the government to yield, but protest leaders said they would now end their demonstrations and go home.

Alexander Novak, **Russia's** deputy prime minister, said the government would maintain a ban on **petrol** exports until the end of the year. It is considering extending a ban on diesel exports for another month. Ukrainian drone attacks on refineries have caused

fuel shortages and queues at petrol stations, [bringing the war home](#) to ordinary Russians.

Democrats in **Maine** chose a new nominee for the must-win Senate race in November, after the previous candidate, [Graham Platner](#), dropped out following allegations of sexual assault that he denies. Troy Jackson is a fifth-generation logger and former Maine Senate president. He will take on five-term Republican, Susan Collins. Democrats need a net gain of four seats for a Senate majority.

SpaceX completed the 13th flight of its **Starship** reusable rocket. It is the first big test of Elon Musk's rocket-and-AI conglomerate since its blockbuster initial public offering in June. The rocket's splashdown was so gentle that its booster phase floated on the ocean rather than exploding, as some previous versions have. SpaceX described it as its best re-entry yet.

An intern at **NATO's** military headquarters in Belgium was arrested for **spying**. Belgian authorities said the woman is a Canadian national of Chinese origin, but did not say for whom she is accused of snooping. In 2021 NATO expelled eight people it accused of spying as part of a Russian delegation to the alliance, causing Russia to suspend its diplomatic mission.

Mr Trump alternately joked with and lambasted journalists at the rescheduled **White House correspondents' dinner** in Washington. The president shook hands with critics but accused many of having "Trump Derangement Syndrome". He ended his speech by donning a hat that read "Trump 2028". The original dinner [was terminated](#) in April when a gunman burst through security.

Word of the week: Pix, the name of Brazil's much-loved payments system. [Our story explains](#) why it has drawn Donald Trump's ire.

Democrats try to turn the corner in Maine



Photograph: Getty Images

Democrats in Maine will gather on Saturday to nominate a Senate candidate to replace Graham Platner, [a scandal-ridden, oyster-farming populist](#) who suspended his campaign on July 8th following a rape allegation (which he denies). After a rollercoaster few months for the state's Democrats, the convention is unlikely to generate much drama. The replacement process has been quick. Troy Jackson, a former state senator, has secured enough support from party delegates in under two weeks, making the convention merely a formality.

Mr Jackson, a 58-year-old fifth-generation logger from Maine's northernmost reaches, speaks with a distinctive lilt. A staunch progressive, he supports universal health care and abolishing Immigration and Customs Enforcement. He faces a formidable opponent. Susan Collins, the Republican incumbent seeking her sixth term, has some \$11m in campaign funds. Mr Jackson has just \$1m. And he has also already had to respond to allegations: former colleagues told [CNN](#) he has a temper, and said he threw a water bottle at a fellow legislator.

The travails of Takaichi Sanae



Photograph: Getty Images

Japan's parliament closes on Saturday, after its latest session was extended by a week to let parties finish their legislative business. A deadlock over several bills, including one to create a “second capital” outside Tokyo, had caused delays.

The impasse shows how much [Takaichi Sanae](#), the prime minister, has been flagging lately. Despite her Liberal Democratic Party winning a two-thirds supermajority in the lower house in February, she has struggled to enact her agenda, which is both socially conservative and spendthrift. Her government has managed to push through some divisive policies, such as a bill which would [keep women off the throne](#). But her once sky-high approval ratings have taken a dive. She initially won the public over with her everywoman background and punishing work ethic. But her recent bragging about sleeping for barely three hours a day has concerned and alienated many voters. Ms Takaichi may want some proper rest before the legislative battles to come.

Senegal's political schism widens



Photograph: Getty Images

Senegal's newest political party will announce its first leader and statutes on Saturday. Bassirou Diomaye Faye, the country's president, promised to establish the outfit in May after ousting his prime minister, Ousmane Sonko. The longtime allies had been feuding for months, mostly over Mr Faye's attempts to negotiate a deal with the International Monetary Fund to restructure [Senegal's enormous debt](#), which the IMF reckons to be 130% of GDP. Mr Sonko opposes the deal.

The split cost Mr Faye dearly: he lost the support of most of PASTEF, the party that dominates Senegal's national assembly. His new party is meant to unite his remaining supporters ahead of parliamentary elections next year and a presidential ballot in 2029. Meanwhile, Mr Sonko, now the parliamentary speaker, has been trying to capitalise on his support from PASTEF to introduce constitutional reforms. These would, among other things, prevent a sitting president from serving as a party leader. Mr Faye and Mr Sonko increasingly look like bitter rivals.

Mathematics' top prize



Photograph: Getty Images

Many non-mathematicians will be familiar with the Fields Medal as the accolade held by Professor Lambeau in “Good Will Hunting”, a film from 1997. The award—often dubbed the “Nobel Prize of mathematics”—is decided by the International Mathematical Union every four years. The 2026 winners were announced this week: Yu Deng of the University of Chicago, John Pardon of Stony Brook University, Jacob Tsimerman of the University of Toronto and Hong Wang of New York University. Each received C\$15,000 (\$10,600) and a medal decorated with the head of Archimedes.

The winners were recognised for solving or advancing problems that had stumped mathematicians for decades. For example, Dr Wang and her co-author, Joshua Zahl, proved the Kakeya conjecture in three dimensions—a fiendishly difficult problem that dates back to 1917 and asks how an infinitely thin needle can be pointed in every direction while sweeping out as little area as possible. Dr Wang’s 127-page paper can definitely be said to have moved the needle.

Weekend profile: Sonam Wangchuk, India's hunger-striker in chief



Photograph: Getty Images

Since [Mahatma Gandhi's](#) hunger strikes more than a century ago, Indians have routinely fasted as an act of protest. So frequently has this tool been wielded that the state—and indeed many Indians—have grown inured to it. So when Sonam Wangchuk began a fast in Delhi last month, demanding the resignation of India's education minister over [a series of exam-related scandals](#), few expected much to come of it.

Over the past week, India has been rocked by its biggest protests in years. Mr Wangchuk was the catalyst. The activist allied himself with the Cockroach Janta Party 9 (cjp), a youth-protest group (so-called after a judge referred to unemployed young people as “cockroaches”). For 20 days the 59-year-old, calling himself an “honorary cockroach”, wasted away. On July 18th police whisked him to a public hospital.

Their heavy-handed intervention infuriated the cjp's supporters. Two days later tens of thousands of youngsters began a march on Parliament; they were met with tear-gas and batons. Mr Wangchuk kept fasting through the chaos. Only on Friday did he finally break his fast, after receiving assurances from the government that the protesters would not be punished. A day later the cjp got their main

demand, when Dharmendra Pradhan, the education minister, resigned.

Mr Wangchuk has clashed with India's ruling Bharatiya Janata Party before. For years he has fought for statehood for Ladakh, his native Himalayan territory, which is administered directly from Delhi. That campaign included a 21-day hunger strike and his detention by police in 2024.

Yet Mr Wangchuk's life is defined less by political activism than his work on education reform. Raised in a remote village, he did not enter a classroom until he was nine. When he did, at a school in the biggest city in the region, he struggled because lessons were in Urdu, not his native Ladakhi. The experience convinced him that India's education system needed fixing.

Along with his brothers and friends, he formed a non-profit organisation focused on improving Ladakh's education system. Later he launched Operation New Hope, a grassroots programme that transformed the territory's government schools by giving local communities more authority. He trained as an engineer, which helped him create a series of innovations designed for life in the high Himalayas, including an ice stupa that stores winter meltwater during parched summers.

His exploits were deemed heroic enough even for Bollywood. Mr Wangchuk supposedly inspired the lead character in a hit from 2009 about India's flawed education system. He has long downplayed the connection. But through his role in the protests, he has emerged as a real-life hero for many. Indians concerned about the state of their country's democracy look to him and his fellow cockroaches for hope.

Mini crossword

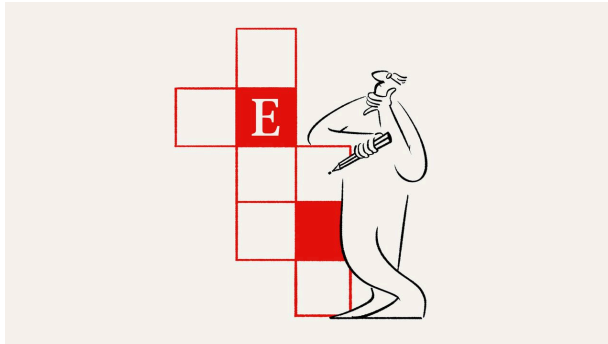


Illustration: The Economist

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - A student tradition: drop cat. It adds up! (6)

2 across - Kudu lost bug, adopted daughter, ran off (6)

3 across - Unable to disperse dust cloud (6)

1 down - A willing but heartless chap conquered headless Greek king (9)

Straight clues

1 across - Ancient sort of calculator (6)

2 across - Ran away to marry (6)

3 across - Cloud of dust and gas (6)

1 down - Mythological Greek king (9)

The winners of this week's quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Jason Crider, Naperville, Illinois, America

Richard Small, Johannesburg, South Africa

Alison Wiebalck, Zurich, Switzerland

They all gave the correct answers of: shampoo, The Bangles, Loot, cot and dinghy. The theme is that they are all English words that derive from Hindi or other Indian languages.

The questions were:

Monday: Head & Shoulders is the best selling brand of which type of household product?

Tuesday: Which all-female rock group had hits such as "Walk Like An Egyptian" and "Manic Monday"?

Wednesday: Which Joe Orton play features the corrupt policeman Inspector Truscott?

Thursday: What is the common British term for a bed surrounded by bars and designed for a baby or small child?

Friday: The ILCA 7, ILCA 6 and Mixed 470 are Olympic categories for racing which kind of boat?

*Common sense in an uncommon
degree is what the world calls
wisdom.*

Samuel Taylor Coleridge